

CSS Hyphens & Hyphenate-Characters

Complete Guide: Text Breaking and Hyphenation

CSS Guide

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 What are Hyphens and Hyphenate-Characters?

The CSS `hyphens` property and `hyphenate-characters` property control how text breaks and wraps across lines, including automatic hyphenation. These properties enable proper text justification and prevent awkward line breaks, especially important for justified text and narrow columns.

```
/* Enable automatic hyphenation */
hyphens: auto;

/* Specify custom hyphen character */
hyphenate-character: "-";

/* Use different hyphen character */
hyphenate-character: "=";
```

These properties are essential for professional typography, improving readability in constrained layouts like narrow columns, mobile screens, and justified text.

1.2 Why Hyphenation Matters

1.2.1 Real-World Applications

- **Justified Text:** Creates even text blocks without gaps
- **Narrow Columns:** Prevents awkward spacing in magazine layouts
- **Mobile Display:** Better text fitting on small screens
- **Multilingual Content:** Proper hyphenation for different languages
- **Print Documents:** Professional-looking printed text
- **Code Display:** Breaking long identifiers gracefully

1.2.2 Benefits

- Improved readability and text flow
- Better space utilization

- Professional typography appearance
- Reduced awkward line breaks
- Language-aware breaking rules
- Customizable hyphen characters

1.3 Browser Support

Both properties have good browser support:

Browser	hyphens	hyphenate-characters
Chrome/Edge	v55+	v106+
Firefox	v43+	Limited
Safari	v13+	Limited
Opera	v42+	Limited
IE 11		

Chapter 2

The Hyphens Property

2.1 What Hyphens Does

The `hyphens` property controls automatic hyphenation of words in justified or constrained text layouts.

2.1.1 Available Values

Value	Behavior	When Used
none	No hyphenation	Words never break
manual	Hyphenate at soft hyphens	Only at explicit marks
auto	Browser decides	Automatic intelligent breaking

2.1.2 Value Explanations

```
/* No hyphenation - words stay intact */
p {
  hyphens: none;
}

/* Only at soft hyphens (shy;) */
p {
  hyphens: manual;
}

/* Automatic hyphenation by browser */
p {
  hyphens: auto;
  /* Language matters - use lang attribute */
}
```

2.2 Practical Usage

2.2.1 Example 1: Justified Text

```
/* Justified paragraph with hyphenation */
.justified {
  text-align: justify;
  hyphens: auto;
  lang: en; /* HTML attribute */
}

/* Result: Text breaks naturally with hyphens
   where appropriate */
```

2.2.2 Example 2: Narrow Columns

```
/* Magazine-style narrow column */
.column {
  width: 300px;
  hyphens: auto;
  text-align: justify;
}

.article-container {
  columns: 2;
  column-gap: 20px;
  hyphens: auto;
}
```

2.2.3 Example 3: Mobile Text

```
/* Mobile-friendly text breaking */
body {
  hyphens: auto;
  text-align: justify;
}

@media (max-width: 480px) {
  body {
    hyphens: auto;
    text-align: left;
  }
}
```

2.3 Language-Specific Hyphenation

Hyphenation rules vary by language. Use the HTML `lang` attribute:

```
/* CSS must work with HTML lang attribute */
p:lang(en) {
  hyphens: auto; /* English rules */
}
```

```
p:lang(de) {  
    hyphens: auto; /* German rules */  
}  
  
p:lang(fr) {  
    hyphens: auto; /* French rules */  
}  
  
/* In HTML: */  
/* <p lang="en">English text</p> */  
/* <p lang="de">Deutscher Text</p> */  
/* <p lang="fr">Texte français</p> */
```


Chapter 3

Soft Hyphens and Manual Hyphenation

3.1 The Soft Hyphen Character

The soft hyphen (­ or \u00AD) suggests where text can break with a hyphen if needed:

3.1.1 Using Soft Hyphens

```
/* HTML with soft hyphens */
<!-- Hyphenation Points Marked -->
<p>
    Su&shy;per&shy;cal&shy;i&shy;frag&shy;i&shy;lis&shy;tic&shy;ex&shy;pi&shy;a&shy;li&shy;
</p>

/* CSS for manual hyphenation */
p {
    hyphens: manual; /* Only breaks at shy; */
}
```

3.2 Manual vs Automatic

```
/* Manual: Only at soft hyphens */
.manual-text {
    hyphens: manual;
    width: 200px;
}

/* Automatic: Browser decides */
.auto-text {
    hyphens: auto;
    width: 200px;
    lang: en;
}

/* Combination: Use both */
```

```
.hybrid-text {  
  hyphens: auto;  
  width: 200px;  
  lang: en;  
  /* Soft hyphens provide fallback hints */  
}
```

Chapter 4

The Hyphenate-Characters Property

4.1 What Hyphenate-Characters Does

The `hyphenate-characters` property specifies which characters to use when hyphenating text. It accepts two characters: the pre-break character and post-break character.

4.1.1 Syntax

```
/* Character(s) to show when breaking */
hyphenate-characters: "-";           /* Just hyphen */
hyphenate-characters: "--";          /* Before & after break */
hyphenate-characters: "- ";          /* Hyphen and space */
hyphenate-characters: "\2010";        /* Unicode hyphen */
```

4.1.2 Common Characters

Character	Code	Use Case
Hyphen (-)	"-"	Standard (most common)
Double hyphen (--)	"--"	Emphasized breaks
Equals (=)	"="	Programming context
Unicode hyphen	"\2010"	Typographic hyphen

4.2 Practical Examples

4.2.1 Example 1: Standard Hyphenation

```
/* Default hyphen (most common) */
.justified-text {
  hyphens: auto;
  hyphenate-characters: "-";
  text-align: justify;
}

/* Result: "Supercal-" on one line,
           "ifragilistic" on next */
```

4.2.2 Example 2: Custom Hyphen Character

```
/* Use double hyphen for emphasis */
.emphasized {
  hyphens: auto;
  hyphenate-characters: "--";
}

/* Use equals for programming */
.code {
  hyphens: auto;
  hyphenate-characters: "=";
}

/* Typographic hyphen (em dash) */
.elegant {
  hyphens: auto;
  hyphenate-characters: "\2010";
}
```

4.2.3 Example 3: Language-Specific Hyphenation

```
/* English with standard hyphen */
p:lang(en) {
  hyphens: auto;
  hyphenate-characters: "-";
}

/* German with different character */
p:lang(de) {
  hyphens: auto;
  hyphenate-characters: "=";
}

/* French with custom character */
p:lang(fr) {
  hyphens: auto;
  hyphenate-characters: "-";
}
```

Chapter 5

Practical Examples

5.1 Example 1: Magazine-Style Article

```
/* Multi-column justified article */
article {
    columns: 3;
    column-gap: 30px;
    text-align: justify;
    hyphens: auto;
    lang: en;
    hyphenate-characters: "-";
}

article h2 {
    column-span: all;
    hyphens: none;
}

article p {
    margin-bottom: 1em;
}

/* Mobile: Single column */
@media (max-width: 1024px) {
    article {
        columns: 2;
    }
}

@media (max-width: 768px) {
    article {
        columns: 1;
    }
}
```

5.2 Example 2: Narrow Sidebar

```
/* Sidebar with constrained width */
.sidebar {
  width: 250px;
  hyphens: auto;
  text-align: justify;
}

.sidebar p {
  margin-bottom: 10px;
  line-height: 1.5;
}

.sidebar a {
  word-break: break-word;
}

/* Allow long URLs to break */
.sidebar code {
  hyphens: auto;
  word-break: break-word;
  background: #f5f5f5;
  padding: 5px;
}
```

5.3 Example 3: Justified Blog Post

```
/* Professional blog styling */
.blog-post {
  max-width: 800px;
  margin: 0 auto;
  text-align: justify;
  hyphens: auto;
  line-height: 1.8;
}

.blog-post p {
  margin-bottom: 1.5em;
  text-indent: 2em;
}

.blog-post p:first-of-type {
  text-indent: 0;
}

/* Emphasized sections */
.blog-post blockquote {
  hyphens: auto;
  text-align: justify;
  margin: 2em;
  padding: 1em;
  border-left: 4px solid #667eea;
```

```
}
```

5.4 Example 4: Code Display with Hyphenation

```
/* Long code identifiers */
.code-block {
  hyphens: auto;
  hyphenate-characters: "=";
  word-break: break-word;
  overflow-wrap: break-word;
  background: #f5f5f5;
  padding: 15px;
  border-radius: 4px;
}

code {
  hyphens: auto;
  font-family: 'Courier New', monospace;
  font-size: 14px;
}

/* Very long variable names */
.long-variable {
  hyphens: auto;
  hyphenate-characters: "_";
}
```

5.5 Example 5: Responsive Mobile Typography

```
/* Desktop: Justified with hyphenation */
@media (min-width: 1024px) {
  p {
    text-align: justify;
    hyphens: auto;
    line-length: 65 characters;
  }
}

/* Tablet: Left-aligned with light hyphenation */
@media (min-width: 768px) and (max-width: 1023px) {
  p {
    text-align: left;
    hyphens: manual;
  }
}

/* Mobile: No hyphenation, left aligned */
@media (max-width: 767px) {
  p {
    text-align: left;
  }
}
```

```
    hyphens: none;  
  }  
}
```


Chapter 6

Advanced Techniques

6.1 Combining with Other CSS Properties

6.1.1 Text Alignment

```
/* Hyphenation works best with justified */
.justified {
    text-align: justify;
    hyphens: auto;
}

/* Can also use with left-aligned */
.left-aligned {
    text-align: left;
    hyphens: auto;
    overflow-wrap: break-word;
}
```

6.1.2 Column Layouts

```
/* Hyphenation in multi-column layouts */
.multi-column {
    columns: 3;
    column-gap: 20px;
    hyphens: auto;
    text-align: justify;
}

/* Prevent heading breaks */
.multi-column h2 {
    column-span: all;
    hyphens: none;
}

/* Prevent figure breaks */
.multi-column figure {
    break-inside: avoid;
    hyphens: none;
}
```

```
}
```

6.1.3 Word Spacing Control

```
/* Fine-tune justified text */
.justified {
    text-align: justify;
    hyphens: auto;
    word-spacing: normal;
    letter-spacing: normal;
    text-justify: inter-word;
}

/* With custom word spacing */
.justified-tight {
    text-align: justify;
    hyphens: auto;
    word-spacing: -0.05em;
}
```

6.2 Language Detection

```
/* Language-specific rules */
:lang(en) { hyphens: auto; }
:lang(de) { hyphens: auto; } /* German: longer words */
:lang(fr) { hyphens: auto; }
:lang(es) { hyphens: auto; }

/* Different hyphen per language */
:lang(en) { hyphenate-characters: "-"; }
:lang(de) { hyphenate-characters: "="; }
:lang(fr) { hyphenate-characters: "-"; }
```

Chapter 7

Browser Support & Fallbacks

7.1 Feature Support

Feature	Chrome	Firefox	Safari
hyphens: manual	v55+	v43+	v13+
hyphens: auto	v55+	v43+	v13+
hyphenate-characters	v106+	Limited	Limited

7.2 Fallback Strategy

```
/* Works everywhere with fallback */
p {
  text-align: justify;
  hyphens: manual; /* Supported broadly */
  word-wrap: break-word;
  overflow-wrap: break-word;
}

/* Enhanced for modern browsers */
@supports (hyphens: auto) {
  p {
    hyphens: auto;
  }
}
```

Chapter 8

Best Practices

8.1 Key Recommendations

8.1.1 1. Always Provide Language Hint

```
/* Good: Language specified */
p[lang="en"] {
    hyphens: auto;
}

/* In HTML: */
/* <p lang="en">English text</p> */

/* Using root element */
html { lang: en; }
```

8.1.2 2. Use Auto Judiciously

```
/* Good: Auto for justified text */
.justified {
    text-align: justify;
    hyphens: auto;
}

/* Avoid: Auto for headings */
h1 {
    hyphens: none;
}
```

8.1.3 3. Test Hyphenation

Test in:

- Different browsers
- Different languages
- Different screen sizes

- Different text lengths

8.1.4 4. Combine with Word Breaking

```
/* Comprehensive text breaking strategy */
p {
  hyphens: auto;
  word-break: normal;
  word-wrap: break-word;
  overflow-wrap: break-word;
}

/* URLs should break differently */
a {
  word-break: break-all;
  hyphens: manual;
}
```

Chapter 9

Common Issues & Solutions

9.1 Issue 1: Hyphenation Not Working

Problem: `hyphens: auto` has no effect.

Causes:

- No `lang` attribute set
- Browser doesn't support
- Not in justified or constrained context

Solution:

```
/* Ensure lang attribute */
<p lang="en">Text here</p>

/* CSS for hyphenation */
p {
    hyphens: auto;
    text-align: justify;
    width: 300px; /* Constraint needed */
}
```

9.2 Issue 2: Over-Hyphenation

Problem: Too many hyphenated lines.

Solution:

```
/* Use manual instead of auto */
p {
    hyphens: manual; /* Only at soft hyphens */
}

/* Increase line length */
p {
    width: 400px; /* From 300px */
    hyphens: auto;
}
```

9.3 Issue 3: Incorrect Language Hyphenation

Problem: Wrong hyphenation rules applied.

Solution:

```
/* Set correct language */
<p lang="en">English text</p>  <!-- Correct -->
<p lang="de">Deutscher Text</p>  <!-- German rules -->

/* CSS by language */
p:lang(en) { hyphens: auto; }
p:lang(de) { hyphens: auto; }
```

Chapter 10

Summary & Quick Reference

10.1 When to Use Hyphens

Use `hyphens` when:

- Justified text needs improvement
- Content in narrow columns
- Mobile-friendly typography needed
- Professional text presentation required

10.2 When to Use `hyphenate-characters`

Use `hyphenate-characters` when:

- Custom hyphen display needed
- Special formatting required
- Technical documentation
- Custom typography needs

10.3 Quick Reference

10.3.1 Common Patterns

```
/* Justified text with hyphenation */
.justified {
    text-align: justify;
    hyphens: auto;
}

/* Narrow column text */
.narrow {
    width: 250px;
    hyphens: auto;
```



```
}

/* Manual hyphenation only */
.manual {
  hyphens: manual;
}

/* Custom hyphen character */
.custom {
  hyphens: auto;
  hyphenate-characters: "-";
}

/* No hyphenation */
.no-break {
  hyphens: none;
}
```

10.3.2 Complete Example

```
@media (min-width: 1024px) {
  .article {
    columns: 2;
    column-gap: 30px;
    text-align: justify;
    hyphens: auto;
  }
}

@media (max-width: 1023px) {
  .article {
    columns: 1;
    text-align: left;
    hyphens: none;
  }
}
```

Thank you for reading!

For more information, visit [MDN Web Docs](#) and [web.dev](#)